

Cambodian Incursion

In spring 1970, Nixon decided to risk public criticism and attack Viet Cong and NVA bases in Cambodia, an officially neutral country. He also wanted to shore up Lon Nol, Cambodia's newly installed pro-American premier, and send an intimidating message to the North.

◀◀ BEFORE

By 1970, President Nixon and Henry Kissinger were conducting peace negotiations in private.

FIGHTING AND TALKING

On February 21, 1970, Henry Kissinger had begun secret **talks with North Vietnam's Le Duc Tho** in Paris. Private meetings were evidence of Nixon's and Kissinger's **secretive conduct** of the war and of their concern to use political pressure as well as military means to force a settlement. Le Duc Tho demanded US withdrawal from Vietnam and a role for the **People's Revolutionary Government**, the political arm of the Viet Cong.

Following the coup in Phnom Penh in March 1970, the new prime minister General Lon Nol quickly offered military cooperation with the United States as a way of controlling communist activity. Although Nixon had publicly declared that the United States had no advance warning of the coup, it was clear that the change of leadership was welcomed by the United States.

Entering the Parrot's Beak

On April 30, 1970, at the request of General Abrams, Nixon ordered incursions into Cambodia. The plan and execution of the incursion was a joint operation with South Vietnamese forces and a combat test of Vietnamization.

The operation opened with an 8,000-man ARVN force accompanied by about 100 US advisers attacking the portion of the border known as the Parrot's Beak, only 24 miles (40 km) west of Saigon. The goal was to encircle and destroy a large concentration of North Vietnamese (NVA) forces there. Two days later, a primarily American force attacked the "Fishhook," some 48 miles (80 km) north of Saigon and believed to be the site of the Central Office for South Vietnam (COSVN), the nerve center of the Viet Cong, which US intelligence believed was operating out of Cambodia.

Over the following weeks, the attacking ARVN and US forces often operated independently in multibattalion cross-border attacks or in brief raids. Some stayed to occupy an area to provide support for the army of Lon Nol's Cambodian government (FANK), and others quickly went back to South Vietnam. The FANK forces largely retreated toward Phnom Penh. All of these actions had US air and artillery support. Also, strict rules of engagement were observed that limited US forces to proceed no more than 18 miles (30 km) into Cambodia and required ARVN to stay within 31 miles (50 km) of the border. Within a week, a joint force of 31,000 US troops and 19,000 ARVN were ranged along a 100-mile (160 km) stretch of the South Vietnam-Cambodian border.

"Electrify people with a **bold decision**.
[They will] **make history**."

RICHARD NIXON, MAY 1, 1970